

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART ONE · STORY

CHAPTER 1 · STRUCTURE

Rules Before We Break Them

HOLLYWOOD BLVD. · THE ROAD THE ROOM TOOK

Casablanca · 1942 · 102 min · dir. Michael Curtiz · Warner Bros.

CHAPTER 1 OF 9

This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner, and this one went straight on.

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

VOTED

CASABLANCA

1942 · 102 min · dir. Michael Curtiz · Warner Bros.

🏆 WON 3 ACADEMY AWARDS IN 1944, INCLUDING BEST PICTURE

The blueprint, run at full power. You can see every joint and feel every turn coming, and it still works better here than it has worked anywhere since. That is not a flaw in the film, that is the entire case for the blueprint.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

HALF THE SCRIPT DID NOT EXIST WHEN THE CAMERAS ROLLED

Shooting ran **May 25 to August 3, 1942**, and unusually it was shot mostly *in sequence*, because only the first half of the screenplay was ready. New pages arrived on set each morning. Howard Koch, flatly: *"When we began, we didn't have a finished script."* Curtiz told Ingrid Bergman to play it "in between."

One correction to the legend, since you'll hear it repeated: it is not true that nobody knew how the film ended. The writers had that argued out in memos before a frame was shot, and the Production Code left them very little room. What was genuinely unresolved was the film's last line, which Bogart came back to dub a month after the wrap.

THE PEOPLE IN THE BACKGROUND ARE NOT ACTING LIKE REFUGEES

Almost the entire supporting cast was foreign born, and a great many of them, credited and not, had fled the exact thing the film is about. Historian Aljean Harmetz: they brought to a dozen small roles *"an understanding and a desperation that could never have come from Central Casting."* The director, Michael Curtiz, was a Hungarian Jewish émigré born Mihály Kertész.

Conrad Veidt, who plays Major Strasser, was German and not Jewish. When Goebbels made the film industry fill out a racial questionnaire in 1933, Veidt wrote *"Jude"* rather than renounce his Jewish wife. He left for Britain, gave a large share of his savings to the British war effort, and wrote into his Hollywood contract that any German he played must be a villain. He was the highest paid actor on the picture and died six months after it opened.

Marcel Dalio, the croupier, had been a major star in France. The Nazis used posters of his face as the image of "a typical Jew." The rest of his family died in the camps. **Madeleine Lebeau**, who plays Yvonne, was nineteen, and escaped Paris with Dalio on Chilean visas that turned out to be forgeries.

NOBODY INVOLVED THOUGHT THEY WERE MAKING ANYTHING SPECIAL

Budgeted at **\$878,000**, delivered at **\$1,039,000**. Shot almost entirely on the Warner Bros. Burbank lot. The Paris street is a set that had just been built for *The Desert Song* and redressed.

Then history did the studio a favour it could not have bought. The Allies landed at Casablanca on **November 8, 1942**. Warner Bros. rushed the premiere to November 26. Roosevelt and Churchill met in Casablanca that January, and the film went into general release on **January 23, 1943**, inside the conference window.

A counter fact worth keeping in your pocket: the Office of War Information blocked screenings of the film for American troops stationed in North Africa, worried it would inflame Vichy sympathisers in the region.

02

WHILE YOU WATCH

~10:00

THE HAND BEFORE THE FACE

The camera cranes down into the café and drifts table to table, eavesdropping. Then it settles on a close up of **a hand signing a check "OK Rick"**, and only then tilts up to Bogart, alone, playing chess against himself. He doesn't look up.

Why it matters: the film spends ten full minutes letting everyone talk about a man before it will show him to you, then introduces him signature first, face second. He is a reputation before he is a person. And a man playing chess against himself is the whole movie in one image.

~32:00

WATCH SAM, NOT ILSA

When the song is requested, watch the piano player instead. Sam tries to steer her off it, and keeps glancing toward the back of the room. **He is watching for Rick before you are.** Then the cut: Rick striding over, furious, and the sentence dies mid word.

Why it matters: the single biggest turn in the film is executed with blocking and a broken sentence rather than dialogue. The line breaks partly because the Hays Office made them cut Rick's original version of it, which had a swear word in it.

~70:00

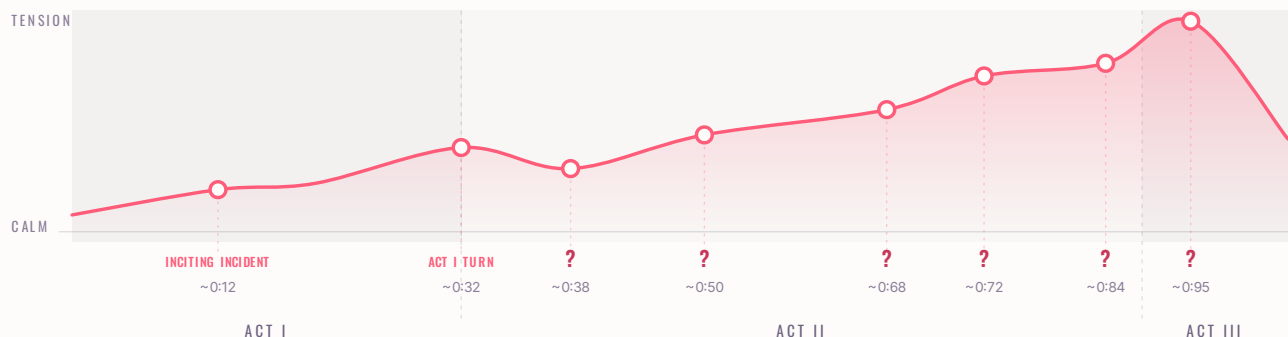
THE FACES, NOT THE SONG

Curtiz cuts away from his stars into a run of **tight close ups of extras**: the croupier, the waiter, and Yvonne, who has spent the night drinking with a German officer and now stands up singing with tears running down her face.

Why it matters: this is where the private story gets steamrolled by the public one, and it isn't quite acting. A witness on set said many of the performers were crying and he "realized that they were all real refugees." Leslie Epstein, on Lebeau's close up: "*They're not tears of glycerin shed by an actress.*"

03

THE SHAPE OF IT



A long flat setup, a climb that never quite stops climbing, one peak, and a landing that takes about five minutes. That is the whole three act structure in one line. Each mark is a moment where the film turns and does not turn back. The first two are named so you can see how to read it. The rest are yours to find, and they're the conversation on Sunday. Timings are approximate, so give them a couple of minutes either way.

"Play it again, Sam" is never said in this film

Ilsa says "Play it once, Sam. For old times' sake... Play it, Sam. Play 'As Time Goes By.'" Rick says "You played it for her, you can play it for me... Play it!" The famous line comes from decades of people misremembering, and later from Woody Allen putting it on a marquee.

Dooley Wilson could not play the piano

He was a professional **drummer**, borrowed from Paramount. Watch his hands on a rewatch. Who actually dubbed it is still genuinely disputed: credited for decades to Elliot Carpenter, but payroll records and a forensic musicologist point instead to studio pianist Jean Plummer. Warner Bros. also considered dubbing Wilson's *singing* voice, and thankfully didn't.

The plane in the last scene is a plywood cutout

Balsa and plywood models, worked by little person actors in mechanics' overalls to fake the scale. That is what the fog is for. Assistant director Lee Katz: *"To give it forced perspective. And it worked."* Real aircraft footage was shot separately at Van Nuys and cut in.

"Here's looking at you, kid" isn't in any draft of the screenplay

It reportedly came from something Bogart said to Bergman off camera while she played poker between takes with her English coach. And it wasn't his either. It is a documented American bar toast going back to the *New York Herald* in March 1871. It is said four times in the film.

The Ronald Reagan casting story is a myth

Warner Bros.' publicity department planted an item in the *Hollywood Reporter* on January 5, 1942, saying Ann Sheridan and Ronald Reagan would co-star. The screenplay hadn't been started. No casting had happened. Reagan was an Army Reserve lieutenant awaiting call up and couldn't have taken a spring start. Hal Wallis wanted Bogart from the beginning, and a studio memo records the picture was "being written for him."

The half true part: Ann Sheridan genuinely was considered for Ilsa, before Wallis traded Olivia de Havilland's services to Selznick to get Bergman.

A haircut saved "As Time Goes By"

Composer Max Steiner disliked the song and lobbied to replace it with an original. Doing so would have meant reshooting every scene built around it, which was impossible, because Bergman had already cut her hair short for *For Whom the Bell Tolls*.

The word "Jew" never appears in the film

The Bulgarian couple are fleeing "persecution," unspecified. Warner Bros. was the most committed anti-Nazi studio in Hollywood and still avoided naming the Jewish identity of its own staff and stars. Worth sitting with.

102:00

1 Rick does not do a single unselfish thing until roughly the seventy minute mark. Did the film *earn* that turn, or did you grant it to him in the first ten minutes because you already knew who Humphrey Bogart was?

2 Cut the nine minute Paris flashback out entirely and the plot still functions perfectly. So what does the film actually lose?

WHERE TO WATCH

Find it here → justwatch.com/us/movie/casablanca, which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones, and stays current.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card, and between them they carry most of this. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

WHY WE START HERE

ONE IS THE PERFECT ENGINE OF CLASSIC HOLLYWOOD STORYTELLING. THE OTHER WAS BUILT, ON PURPOSE, TO TAKE THAT ENGINE APART WHILE IT'S STILL RUNNING.

In 1941, Preston Sturges made a movie about a director who has decided that the movies he is good at are worthless. One year later, Warner Bros. made a formula picture on a modest budget, on borrowed sets, with a script that wasn't finished when shooting started, and accidentally filmed the best argument anyone has ever made for exactly the kind of movie Sturges was defending. *Neither one knew about the other. They have been arguing ever since.*

Watch one. Or both. Then bring eighty four years of movies with you, and tell me what these two started.

THE STUDY

CLASSICAL HOLLYWOOD FOUNDATIONS

What “structure” means, and why we start in the 1940s.

WHY WE START WITH STRUCTURE

We're not just randomly watching films. We're following an overall story that will help us understand the medium better, and broaden what we even *think* is possible.

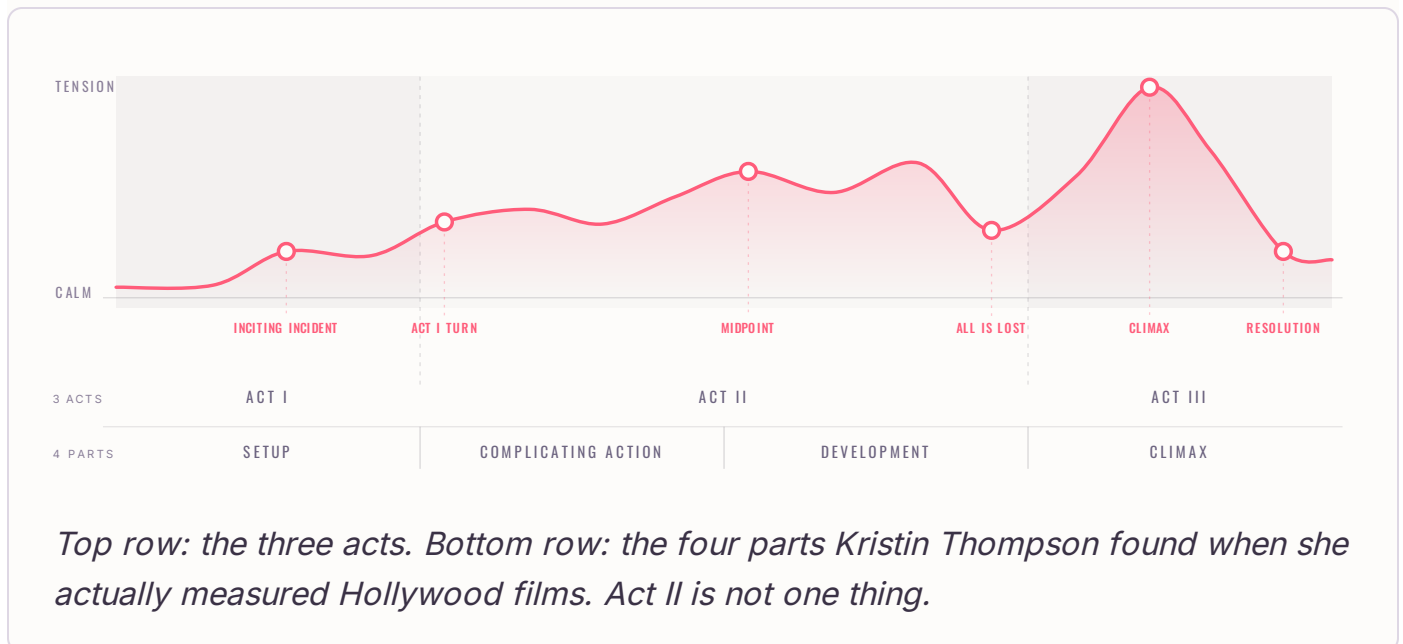
Chapter one is all about **structure**: how a story is presented, and how almost everything still follows, or deliberately rebels against, an ancient format that has been reintroduced and split apart for thousands of years.

If you've ever watched a movie and thought "how did they do that?", if you've ever loved a film so much you wanted the poster, the quote on a mug, the whole world of it, this is for you.

THE SHAPE EVERYONE DRAWS

A film is a contained experience, usually 90 to 120 minutes. That length matches how we hold attention in a dark room. Something happens, obstacles rise, stakes escalate, the story resolves. Cause leads to effect. **Structure is the invisible skeleton we rarely notice when it's working perfectly.**

Here is the diagram you have seen a hundred times.



It is worth knowing where that shape came from, because almost none of it came from film.

FREYTAG WAS WRITING ABOUT TRAGEDY, AND HE COUNTED FIVE

Gustav Freytag published *Die Technik des Dramas* in **1863**. He was analysing Sophocles, Shakespeare, and the German five act play. His model did not have three parts, rather, five.

- 1 *Einleitung*, the introduction
- 2 *Steigerung*, the rise
- 3 *Höhepunkt*, the climax
- 4 *Fall oder Umkehr*, the fall or the turn
- 5 *Katastrophe*

He was theorizing a structure that leads to **catastrophe**, rather than the school taught resolution stories we see all the time now. That last beat is the one that got quietly swapped out somewhere along the way.

Freytag died in 1895, the same year cinema went public. That December the Lumière brothers ran ten short films in the basement of a Paris café and sold tickets, the screening history decided to remember, even though Skladanowsky in Berlin and Latham in New York had both got there first.

Aristotle is the other main voice people reach for, usually by way of the *Poetics*. His beginning, middle, and end was a definition of wholeness, and was never meant as a blueprint. When he actually divides a tragedy, in chapter 18, he uses two halves, *desis* and *lusis*, the binding and the unbinding. The Greek plays he was writing about had no act structure at all.

THE RULEBOOK CAME 37 YEARS AFTER CASABLANCA

Funny enough, the three act rulebook was published in **1979**, in Syd Field's *Screenplay*. He attached page numbers to it.

- 1 **Act I**, pages 1 to 30
- 2 **Act II**, pages 31 to 90
- 3 **Act III**, pages 91 to 120
- 4 Plot points landing around page 25 and page 85

Casablanca and *Citizen Kane*, the two films everyone reaches for when they want to demonstrate the format, were made in 1942 and 1941. Neither was ever taught it the way we have been, because it did not exist yet.

Field was describing what films already did, and development executives then adopted it as a filter. David Bordwell, on the mechanism:

Once the three-act template became public knowledge, development executives embraced it as a way to make script acquisition routine.

A description hardened into a rule because it made saying no easier. And when Bordwell went into the archives looking for studio era writers who actually worked in acts, he came back with this:

I couldn't find any script draft broken into acts.

He found one exception. F. Scott Fitzgerald, writing *Infidelity* for MGM in 1938, laid out eight numbered sequences and grouped them into a first act of 45 pages, a second of 50, and a third of 25, nothing like the 30/60/30 that would come later. His working unit was the *sequence*, not the act.

SO WHAT WERE THEY ACTUALLY DOING

Kristin Thompson counted. In *Storytelling in the New Hollywood*, from 1999, she argues mainstream films break into **four large parts** rather than three acts, setup, complicating action, development, and climax, with a short epilogue after. Each one runs roughly 25 to 35 minutes.

Long films are the tell, **they do not get longer acts, they get more parts**. A three hour film tends to have six.

That is the bottom row on the diagram. The famously protracted second act is not one long act at all, it is two parts with a major turn sitting between them, which is why the midpoint of a film feels like a hinge rather than a middle.

WHAT ACTUALLY SHAPED A 1940S PICTURE

Runtime was set by exhibition. In 1938 the average Warner Bros. feature ran 75 minutes, MGM's ran 88. Double bills meant two features plus a newsreel, a cartoon, and a short all had to fit a turnover schedule, so the ceiling on length was set by the theatre's clock.

The Production Code taxed the third act specifically. It permitted a great deal in acts one and two, provided the ending restored the moral ledger. That is why so many pictures from this period have final reels that feel bolted on.

And the thing that did not shape it, the reel. A 1,000 foot reel runs about eleven minutes, and you will hear that reel changes created act breaks. There is no evidence for it anywhere in the scholarship. Changeover projection exists precisely to make the reel change invisible to the audience, and eleven does not divide into thirty.

WHY WE'RE STARTING HERE

This era crystallized the rules under real pressure. Budgets were tight. Locations were limited. Stories had to be efficient and emotionally clear. The war made personal drama feel urgent and universal. Filmmakers couldn't rely on spectacle, so they relied on script, character, and invisible craft.

So we are not here to learn the rules. We are here to learn the shape that a lot of people later mistook for rules, because that is the only way to tell, when you sit down in front of anything, whether a film is following it or fighting it.

BOTH ROADS END HERE

Two films set out to do the exact opposite thing, and both of them got there. One proved the rules work by obeying them without wasting a single move. The other proved the rules are negotiable by walking away from them halfway through and arriving anyway.

NEXT TIME YOU'RE IN A THEATRE, ASK WHICH ONE THE FILM IS DOING.
FOLLOWING THE SHAPE, OR FIGHTING IT.

WHERE THIS IS GOING

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM

Read it like a schoolbook. **Nine chapters in three parts**, one every two weeks, and every one of them stays up. Part One is the story itself: its shape, its clock, and who is telling it. This chapter is the rulebook, and everything after it is people breaking the rules on purpose.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from the AFI Catalog, the Criterion Collection, the Library of Congress, TCM, Snopes, NPR and contemporary trade reporting.
Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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